

BACK TO SQUARE ONE

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

The snapping of ties between the Left and the Congress-led UPA appears to have brought relief to both sides in Kerala. After a rather "unnatural alliance" at the Centre that lasted for four years, the unlikely bedfellows are back to what they were for over four decades: sworn enemies. The developments in Delhi have given a boost to the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) in the state that launched a campaign against the two-year-old Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government's various policies. Unlike Congress President Sonia Gandhi or External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee who maintained sobriety while bidding farewell to the Left, the Kerala leaders have been vicious in their attacks on the Left. Opposition leader Oommen Chandy says, "The Left has once again exposed its anti-national stripes. It opposes the nuclear deal to help China." The war of words has been duly reciprocated by the Left, as Chief Minister V. S. Achuthanandan states, "Congress was trying to make India a US stooge."

As expected, the renewed rivalry is unlikely to come without a price. Many of the projects that the CPI(M)-led Government had initiated not only got immediate clearance but were allocated massive funds. The LDF Government is now worried about the fate of many of these projects with more than Rs 10,000 crore investments at various stages of approvals and financial support from the Centre. These include two international transshipment container terminals at Vallarpadam in Kochi and at Vizhinjam in Thiruvananthapuram that together account for an investment of Rs 7,500 crore. Though the Vallarpadam project is already under construction, Vizhinjam awaits clearance from the Centre. "The projects that have enjoyed the Centre's support so far may be in limbo with the UPA and the Left at loggerheads. In case the Government falls, these projects will run into costly



delays," fears a top official.

Financial worries aside, it is the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), a constituent of the Opposition UDF in Kerala and the ruling UPA at the Centre, that is likely to bear the brunt of these developments. The party believes the nuclear pact with the US would antagonise the Muslims and if it were to lend support to the UPA, it would further damage its already declining hold in the community. At the same time, the party does not want to sever its four-decade-long ties with the Congress. Ignoring the party's deceased president G. M. Banatwala's last statement that condemned the Indo-US deal wasn't an option either. Hence, the IUML decided the obvious; to run with the hare and hunt with the hound. The



BUSHFIRE: Left leaders burn Bush's effigy (above); IUML leaders at their meet

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